100,000, though final numbers could vary. Many of these buildings are over a century-old, and hence crumbling. The narrow staircases and congested alleys pose a further hazard. Arun Dongre, chief officer, Mumbai Building Repair and Reconstruction Board, MHADA, says that while people residing in the buildings located on Kamathipura's 15 lanes will get about 500 square feet houses, those owning commercial units will get structures of the existing size. A project feasibility committee under Dongre will decide the exact area to be redeveloped and the eligibility and number of tenants to be covered under the project *(see What Next?)*.

At ground zero, the residents are happy that they will get bigger houses. The dilapidated buildings in the area have houses that measure just about 100 to 150 sq. ft. The smallest are just 60 sq ft—the size of a toilet in a normal middle-class house, as local Congress MLA Amin Patel notes—compelling many to sleep on the roads at night. "While others eagerly await the rainy season, we have shivers running down our spines. Every monsoon, there is at least one incident of a dilapidated building collapsing in our locality," says Sachin Karpe of the Kamathipura Landlords Welfare Association (KALWA), which has been trying to get the project off the ground for about 12 years. Satyanand Gajelli of the Kamathipura Vikas Samiti says it is not uncommon to find more than one family living in a "matchbox-sized room". "The floors of these buildings are sinking too," he adds.

There is another pressing reason for the residents to push for this urban renewal project—they hope it will change the way their locality is perceived at large. They complain that the entire Kamathipura, which is essentially a working-class neighbourhood, has been stigmatised as a red-light district even as the flesh trade is restricted to just a couple of lanes in the larger precinct.

WHAT NEXT?

- A high-powered panel under the ACS (housing) and nodal committee under the chief secretary will monitor the project
- A project feasibility commitee will submit a report, in about two months, on the exact area to be redeveloped and the eligibility and number of tenants to be covered under the project
- Following this, a detailed project report (DPR) will be prepared and submitted to the state government for approval
- Given the capital-intensive nature of the project, MHADA will bring private players on board to execute the project
- The tenders are likely to be floated later this year with the work expected to begin next year, probably before the Lok Sabha election
- The successful bidder will draw up the final master plan

Many owners of buildings housing brothels have sold or leased these prime spaces to traders and manufacturers of goods, like bags and jeans. This has led to the number of sex workers gradually dwindling—Patel says that the number has shrunk from 20,000 at its peak to under 1,000 now; locals peg it at about 500. Many of these women have shifted to the distant suburbs of Mumbai to ply their trade. Several sex workers, in fact, stay in places like Mankhurd and Navi Mumbai and visit Kamathipura just for work. Lane number one, which was once referred to as '*hijra gali*', has been taken over by realtors.

"This physical transformation will hopefully change the way people perceive Kamathipura residents," says Gajelli's wife, Sangeeta. "Even getting a taxi to reach here is tough. Some drivers ask us why we women hailing from good families want to go to 'that' area." Dr Vishal Yelle, a local, says that the 'Kamathipura' tag is a deterrent when it comes to getting jobs, marriage proposals, opening bank accounts and getting loans and credit cards. "The people in this area know the value of education... yet many resumes are rejected just because the applicant hails from here," he rues.

That said, in the fast-shrinking red-light district, there is resignation at their impending fate regardless of the makeover, and anxiety that a newer, gentrified Kamathipura may push out whatever remains of the flesh trade. A *gharwali,* or brothel owner, who hails from Karnataka, admits that her time may be up once the new Kamathipura comes up. For, it made more sense to sell the rooms housing multiple plywood partitions for sex workers to service their clients, than continue with the trade. "We may have to leave this place, but where do we go?" asks another sex worker, who too hails from northern Karnataka.

Like the larger Kamathipura, the red-light area, too, has seen a change in its demography. "Earlier, the devdasis from Karnataka and the girls from Nepal made up most of the women here. Now, it is women from Bengal who are in a majority," says Sweety (*name changed*), a sex worker for around 15 years. Dubey (*name changed*), a local, sums up the existential dilemma of the women forced to ply the trade out of compulsion: "*Kyunki paapi pet mann ko kaatata hai* (Because hunger always prevails over the mind)," he says in Mumbaiyya Hindi. "*Dhanda nahin karange to khayenge kaise* (If they do not work, how will they feed themselves)?" The change, it seems, will come at a price. ■